
The Politics of U.S. Television Coverage of Post-Communist Countries

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An analysis of the coverage of post-communist countries by the major U.S. television networks from 1998 to 2009 reveals that U.S. allies receive more positive coverage than do non-allies or adversaries and that there are systematic biases in the representation of many post-Soviet countries.

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THIS study analyzes the coverage of post-communist countries, specifically their politics, by the main television networks in the United States. It compares the extent and the content of the reporting on post-communist states such as Russia, Ukraine, Poland, Romania, Bulgaria, the Czech Republic, Hungary, Belarus, Kazakhstan, Uzbekistan, Kyrgyzstan, Georgia, Turkmenistan, Tajikistan, Armenia, Azerbaijan, and Moldova. The question is whether political factors, such as relations with the United States, affect American television coverage of these countries. A related research question is whether there are significant differences in the extent and the content of coverage of former communist states on major television news programs in the United States.

Analyzing the coverage of post-communist nations by U.S. television networks is important not only from a political communications perspective but also from a comparative politics and foreign policy perspective. Previous studies show that media coverage affects the attitudes of the American public and the United States' foreign policy agenda toward other countries—in particular, Russia (Brewer 2006; Norris 2000; Semetko et al. 1992; Wanta et al. 2004). Western mass-media reporting about post-communist countries became an important political concern in many of these states. In addition, a growing number of politicians and journalists from post-communist nations, specifically from Russia and Poland, raise the question of political biases in the coverage of these countries by mass communications media in the United States. For example, the inoSMI.ru Web site, established by the state-owned RIA Novosti, specializes in publishing online translations of stories from Western newspapers and magazines concerning Russia. In 2005, the Russian

government launched the Russia Today television news channel to counter perceived anti-Russian bias in Western mass media.

The first hypothesis tested in this paper is that U.S. allies among post-communist countries are likely to receive much better coverage compared to adversaries and non-allies, not only in the areas of relations between these countries and the United States but also on other issues, including nonpolitical concerns. This relationship is derived from the indexing theory of political communication and a theory of American political culture. The indexing hypothesis implies that media coverage of U.S. foreign policy mostly reflects the framing and political agendas of government officials. This mechanism was manifested by studying the framing of the Iraq War in U.S. media. Prior to and during the Iraq War, the mainstream media mostly followed the Bush administration and reported their concerns regarding Iraqi weapons of mass destruction (WMD) and the Iraqi government's association with al Qaeda despite a lack of sufficient evidence (Bennett 1990; Bennett et al. 2007; Hayes and Guardino 2010; Mermin 1999).

Our study argues that indexing affects the coverage of U.S. relations with post-communist states as well as of issues such as domestic politics, sports, crime, the economy, and immigrants. Because of the strong moralistic elements in American political culture, allies of the United States are often idealized and represented as the embodiment of "good," while adversaries are presented as "evil." For example, Joseph Stalin was turned into "Uncle Joe" when the Soviet Union and the United States were allies during World War II, and his totalitarian rule and mass political repression were largely overlooked in the United States until the start of the cold war, when Stalin and the Soviet Union were presented in a negative light by U.S. officials and the media (Levering 1976; Lipset 1996, p. 66). Similarly, Afghan mujahideen were often represented in the U.S. media as "freedom fighters" during their war in Afghanistan against the Soviet Union, despite their illiberal Islamist ideology—reflected in their name, which is derived from *jihād*.

U.S. allies are defined in this study as members of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO) or countries that pursue pro-Western policies, including the intention to join NATO. Poland, the Czech Republic, and Hungary joined NATO at the beginning of 1999; Romania, Bulgaria, and Slovakia were granted membership in this military and political alliance in 2004. With the exception of the Baltic states, post-Soviet countries did not become NATO members. The governments of Georgia after the

Rose Revolution at the end of 2003 and Ukraine after the Orange Revolution in late 2004, however, adopted a pro-Western orientation in their foreign policy and declared NATO membership a priority. Although NATO did not offer membership to these states, in April 2008 it did recognize Georgia and Ukraine as potential members, with U.S. government support.

In addition, certain non-NATO post-communist states allied with the United States, to one degree or another, during the wars in Kosovo, Iraq, and Afghanistan. The war in Kosovo in 1999 took place under NATO auspices, and the U.S. military presence in Afghanistan came under a formal NATO umbrella in 2003. Because these tactical alliances were limited to the conflicts in Kosovo, Iraq, and Afghanistan—and were much shorter in duration and much less formal, comprehensive, and stable than NATO—their effect on U.S. television coverage of particular post-communist states is likely to be less pronounced but still significant. We can expect to see evidence of this effect in the news coverage of respective countries' roles in these conflicts and changes in the coverage of post-communist countries before and after these conflicts.

Our second hypothesis is that coverage of Russia by U.S. television networks is negative. This hypothesis is derived from indexing theory, other theories of media bias, and previous studies. The political elite in the United States has been historically biased against Russia, in contrast to many other states that were or still are communist, such as China (Davis and Trani 2009; Lieven 2000a; Tsygankov 2009). This bias is likely to manifest itself in television coverage of post-communist Russia. Most previous studies have found a negative pattern of the coverage of this post-communist country.

Our third hypothesis is that coverage of other post-Soviet countries is likely to be affected by the anti-Russian bias. The U.S. media often referred to the Soviet Union as Russia and may still to a significant extent associate many post-Soviet countries with Russia.

Although bias can be difficult to determine precisely, and the concept of bias is often dismissed as too subjective, many studies address various media biases in political communications and related fields. Media bias is often defined as unbalanced coverage in terms of the amount of positive and negative content. D'Alessio and Allen (2000) define the following types of media bias: gatekeeping bias, which involves the inclusion or exclusion of certain stories; coverage bias, which relates to the relative extent of coverage; and statement bias, which deals with favorability of coverage.

Media bias is also often defined in terms of the political preferences of journalists or their audiences. Some studies argue that the U.S. media as a whole has a liberal bias, because journalists are more politically liberal than the general public (Groseclose 2011). Other studies maintain that significant differences exist in this regard among U.S. media. Whereas certain television or cable networks—ABC, NBC, CBS, PBS, and CNN—are regarded as relatively liberal, others, such as Fox News, are relatively conservative. Similarly, while public radio stations like NPR are perceived to be more liberal, talk radio is perceived as more conservative. There is an analogous dichotomy between more liberal newspapers, such as the *New York Times* and the *Washington Post*, and more conservative counterparts such as the *Wall Street Journal* and the *Washington Times* (Jamieson and Cappella 2008; Iyengar and Hahn 2009; Morris 2007).

Media bias is also defined as deviation from reality or facts. This type of bias is exemplified by the misrepresentation in many U.S. media reports of Iraq as having WMD and the Iraq government under Saddam Hussein as having ties to al Qaeda before the onset of the U.S.-led war with this Middle Eastern country in 2003 (Bennett et al. 2007; Hayes and Guardino 2010; Kuypers 2006). Another instance is the portrayal of Russia as an aggressor during the Georgian–Russian war by many U.S. media outlets, even though Georgia launched the war when it attacked its de facto independent breakaway province of South Ossetia and the Russian peacekeepers stationed there (Bahador and Katchanovski 2010; Heinrich and Tanaev 2009).

Previous Studies

The present article is one of the first academic studies to examine the reporting on post-communist countries by U.S. television networks. Most previous studies have focused on the representation of a single country—Russia, Poland, Ukraine, or Romania—in the Western mass media (Golan and Wanta 2003; Hickman and Trapp 1998; Media Tenor 2004, 2007a, 2007b; Norris 1995; Russia 2004; Semetko et al. 1992). Many studies analyzed coverage of these states only in major print media sources in the United States and other Western countries (Bohush 2009; Hickman and Trapp 1998). U.S. television networks, however, reach a much greater audience than newspapers and magazines (Norris 2000; Pew Research Center 2008).

The absolute majority of previous studies deal with various types of media biases concerning domestic issues in the United States. For example, previous studies have

examined various types of U.S. media bias in coverage of the Democratic and Republican presidential candidates, female presidential contenders, and various racial, ethnic, and religious minorities (D'Alessio and Allen 2000; Falk 2010). Empirical analyses of U.S. television news have also reported “home bias” in the amount of coverage given to domestic stories compared to stories dealing with foreign countries (Pew Research Center 1995). Studies of bias in U.S. coverage of foreign countries since September 11 focus on the Iraq War and other conflicts in the Middle East or the representation of Muslims and Arabs by the mass media in the United States and other Western countries (Bennett et al. 2007; Hayes and Guardino 2010; Kuypers 2006; Poole and Richardson 2006).

Content analysis in previous studies has shown that Russia receives significantly more coverage in U.S. media than other post-communist countries do. A sample of evening news programs on ABC, CBS, and NBC in 1988–92 revealed that 17.3 percent of all foreign news stories were devoted to the Soviet Union or Russia, compared to 2.3 percent to Poland, 2.0 percent to Czechoslovakia, and 1.2 percent to Yugoslavia (Hess 1996, p. 32). In January–October 1998, ABC, CBS, NBC, and CNN news broadcasts produced 342 stories on Russia, 64 on Bosnia, 18 on the Baltic states, and 12 on Poland (Wanta et al. 2004, p. 371).

Both of these studies were conducted in the 1990s. They reveal that Russia and the Soviet Union before its collapse in 1991 received the most foreign coverage from the main U.S. television networks. Russia's prominence in the U.S. media declined significantly after September 11 because of the shifting focus toward Middle Eastern countries, especially Iraq and Afghanistan. Content analysis of evening news programs by ABC, CBS, and NBC, *Time*, and *Newsweek* between July 2003 and July 2004 showed that Russia dropped to the second dozen most covered countries in U.S. media. With regard to post-communist states, however, Russia remained the leader in terms of U.S. news media attention. A much higher number (116) of news reports dealt with Russia than with other post-communist countries (61). Among post-Soviet and East Central European countries, Georgia, Bulgaria, and Poland were the subject of the largest number of stories (Media Tenor 2004).

Although Russia receives more attention than other post-communist countries, most of the coverage is negative (Boykewich 2009; Lieven 2000a, 2000b). A 1995 content analysis of television news programs on ABC, CNN, CSPAN, and CBN, two radio talk shows, and the *New York Times* found that coverage of Russia and Bo-

ris Yeltsin, the Russian president at the time, was very negative (Pew Research Center 1995). Another study concluded that much of the coverage of the two wars in Chechnya in the United States and by the Western media in general, “has been relentlessly one-sided and relentlessly anti-Russian” (Lieven 2000a). Coverage mostly focused on the effects of Russian actions on Chechen civilians, blamed Russia for starting both wars, and largely ignored or minimized the role of attacks carried out by Islamist terrorists and kidnappers in Chechnya at the start of the violent conflict in 1994 and its resumption in 1999 (Lieven 2000a, 2000b).

A study of evening news programs on ABC, CBS, and NBC from 2002 through the middle of 2004 also reported that coverage of Russia was overwhelmingly negative, especially on the issues that received the greatest media attention—the conflict in Chechnya, terrorism, and the Olympic Games (Russia 2004). Content analysis of evening news programs on ABC, CBS, and NBC and in *Time* and *Newsweek* magazines between July 2003 and July 2004 showed that the coverage of Russia, Bulgaria, and Romania was more negative than the coverage of Georgia, the Czech Republic, Poland, and Bosnia. With the exception of Russia, however, the number of stories was too small to make this analysis reliable. For example, it included only two stories concerning the Czech Republic, three regarding Romania, and six about Bulgaria (Media Tenor 2004).

A quantitative study, based on computer content analysis, shows that post-Soviet countries, on average, received in 2008, 2009, 2010, and the first quarter of 2011 more negative coverage in leading global media sources than other post-communist states. Russia, which had significantly more mentions than all other post-Soviet states combined, was consistently at the bottom of the annual and quarterly rankings. In 2008–10, Russia ranked between 171 and 187 among 200 countries covered by the study. In the first quarter of 2011, Russia ranked 185 on this index. The computer-generated content analysis, however, produced a significant variation in the scores of many post-communist countries over this short time period. It was problematic for this method to distinguish the tone of the coverage of Russia and Georgia, which waged a war in 2008 over South Ossetia. Russia, Georgia, and South Ossetia all were coded as receiving extremely negative coverage in 2008.¹

In contrast, another study found that coverage of both Russia and Poland by ABC, CBS, NBC, and CNN in 1998 was neutral and not much different from the coverage of such countries as Canada and Italy (Wanta et al.

2004, p. 373). Most stories about U.S. adversaries (e.g., Cuba, Iran, and North Korea), however, were also coded as being neutral toward these countries. This pattern raises questions about the validity of the coding in this particular study.

Some academic studies indicate that U.S. news media frequently equate Russia with the Soviet Union, and this misrepresentation extends to post-Soviet states. For example, American mass media often refer to members of organized crime from post-Soviet countries as “Russian mafia,” even though academic studies reveal that among immigrants from the former Soviet Union in the United States, most criminals are not Russian citizens or ethnically Russian. Similarly, organized crime networks in Russia include a large proportion of ethnic minorities, primarily Chechens, and people from post-Soviet countries of the Caucasus region, especially Georgia (Finckenauer and Waring 1998).

Commercial firms have conducted a few studies of the representation of Ukraine by Western mass media, but they have not released all their findings (Bohush 2009; Media Tenor 2007b). The Western mass media usually associate Ukraine with the Orange Revolution, political instability, the Chernobyl nuclear disaster, and contentious relations with Russia (Bohush 2009). U.S. media coverage of Ukraine-related companies—as is also true of reporting on Poland, Croatia, and many other East Central European and Balkan countries—was generally positive in the first half of 2007. This contrasted with mostly negative American media coverage of Russian and Belarusian companies. With the exception of Russia, however, the number of reports on Ukraine and other post-communist states in that study was extremely small, typically several per country (Media Tenor 2007b).

The “color revolutions” in Georgia in 2003, Ukraine in 2004, and Kyrgyzstan in 2005 received significant media attention in the West. Previous studies argue that Western reporting concerning these political developments has been overwhelmingly positive and similar to coverage of the Velvet Revolution in Czechoslovakia in 1989. Western media presented mass political demonstrations in response to attempts at election fraud as democratic pro-Western revolutions (Schipani-Adúriz 2007).

Data and Methodology

This study uses quantitative and content analyses of news programs about post-communist countries from the most-watched U.S. television networks—ABC, CBS, and NBC—from 1998 to 2009. We examined the following

evening news programs: *World News*, *Nightline*, and *20/20* on ABC; *CBS Evening News*, *CBS Sunday Night News*, *48 Hours*, *60 Minutes*, and *60 Minutes II* on CBS; and *NBC Nightly News* and *Dateline* on NBC.

These networks and news programs were selected primarily because they have the biggest television audience in the United States. We excluded other broadcast networks such as PBS and cable channels such as Fox News, CNN, and MSNBC because their audience is much smaller, even though the viewership of Fox News has significantly increased since the late 1990s (Pew Research Center's Project 2011). For example, the average median number of primetime viewers in 2008–10 was 1.9 million on Fox News, 0.8 million on CNN, and 0.8 million on MSNBC. In comparison, the average median number of people watching the evening news during the same time period was 7.8 million for *ABC World News*, 5.9 million for *CBS Evening News*, and 8.6 million for *NBC Nightly News*. The audience for all news magazines included in this study also exceeded the total primetime viewership for Fox News and other cable news channels. It ranged in 2008–10 from 3.6 million for *Nightline* to 11.8 million for *60 Minutes* (Pew Research Center's Project 2011). These numbers, derived from data collected by Nielsen Media Research, are more reliable and precise than self-reported survey data. For example, a 2011 Pew Research survey produced a different pattern of viewership. Thirty and 24 percent of Americans, respectively, said that they watched Fox News and CNN regularly, compared to 43 percent who viewed the nightly news on the three traditional networks combined (Pew Research Center 2011, p. 43). The exclusion of Fox News may represent a certain limitation of this study, since previous research has often reported that its coverage differs from the other television channels. A previous study, however, found no significant differences between Fox News and the three leading networks in terms of their coverage of the Georgian–Russian war (Bahador and Katchanovski 2010).

This article covers the following post-Soviet countries: Armenia, Azerbaijan, Belarus, Georgia, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Moldova, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan, Russia, Ukraine, and Uzbekistan.² The Baltic states are not included, because they are small and much less likely to be associated with Russia than other post-Soviet states. In contrast to other post-Soviet countries, Estonia, Latvia, and Lithuania became part of the Soviet Union only as a result of World War II, and their incorporation into the Soviet Union was not recognized by the United States. Poland, the Czech Republic, Romania, Bulgaria, Slovakia, and Hungary are included in this study as post-communist

countries in East Central Europe. The ex-Yugoslav countries and Albania are excluded from the analysis to keep the cold war legacy constant. In contrast to Poland, the Czech Republic, Romania, Bulgaria, Slovakia, and Hungary, communist Yugoslavia and Albania were not Soviet allies during most or all of the cold war.

We employed a keyword search of full-text television transcripts in the Lexis-Nexis database to identify specific broadcasts and news stories that focused on the post-communist countries in the former Soviet Union and East Central Europe. For instance, reports found with the help of the keywords “Ukraine,” “Ukrainian,” and “Ukrainians” are classified as dealing with Ukraine.³ Only stories that devote fifty or more words to a particular post-communist country or people from this country are included in the analysis. The reliance on transcripts gives an incomplete view of news broadcasts, because information presented in visual images is missing. Specifically, this might affect the coding of the content as positive, negative, or neutral. We expect, however, that any potential biases resulting from reliance on transcripts would be uniformly distributed across countries.

To ensure intercoder reliability, one coauthor coded all the data, while the other coauthor coded a large subsection of data. The data sample, which was coded to check reliability, included 618, or 22 percent, of all reports concerning Russia; 247, or 51 percent, on other post-Soviet countries; and 258, or 52 percent, concerning East Central European countries. The size of the combined sample is large (1,123 stories). It includes either large proportions of or all stories dealing with Russia, Ukraine, Poland, Romania, Bulgaria, Hungary, Georgia, the Czech Republic, Armenia, Azerbaijan, and Kazakhstan. The overall reliability coefficient (Alpha) for the entire sample is .75. The reliability scores (Alpha) are .81 for East Central European countries, .69 for Russia, and .84 for other post-Soviet states. Each of the double-coded countries has similarly high reliability coefficients.

The study uses comparisons among different countries to analyze the quantity and the content of their coverage by U.S. television networks. The quantitative analysis involves a comparison of the number, the word count, and the main subject of news stories dealing with specific countries. A qualitative analysis undertakes an examination of the news stories concerning post-communist countries in terms of their positive, neutral, or negative context.

Stories and major subjects of coverage are coded depending on whether they present a positive or negative image of a post-communist country from the perspective

of the United States. Reports that present both positive and negative sides or are neutral are coded as neutral.

For example, reports that focus on a post-communist country's relations with the United States and show the country to be an American ally, emphasize its pro-U.S. foreign policies, or describe visits of foreign officials, agreements, cooperation, and so on without significant references to tensions, disagreements, or conflicts with the United States are coded as positive. Conversely, stories that emphasize adversarial relations with the United States, anti-U.S. policies, tensions, disagreements, conflicts, and so on are coded as negative. Broadcasts that present a post-communist country's relations with the United States in a neutral way or include both positive and negative content in similar proportions are treated as neutral. (See appendix.)

Similarly, coverage of terrorism is coded as positive toward a post-communist country if it focuses on victims while identifying terrorists as nonrepresentative of a country's population. A focus on government failures to prevent terrorist attacks or save hostages, adverse consequences of antiterrorist policies, or identification of terrorists as representative of a country or immigrants from that country is coded as negative. Similar coding criteria were applied to nonpolitical topics, including crime, immigrants, and sport. (See appendix.)

Main Results

The analysis of television news programs on ABC, CBS, and NBC from 1998 to 2009 indicates a bias in terms of the amount of coverage of various post-communist countries when the size of their population is taken into account. It shows that Russia received disproportionate coverage compared to other post-Soviet countries. The number and length of stories dealing with Russia and Russians were six and five times higher, respectively, than the other eleven post-Soviet countries combined, even though their population size is similar. This disparity, however, has declined significantly since 2004. The number of Russia-related stories, compared to the other post-Soviet states, was 3.5 times higher in 2004–9 and 8.5 times higher in 1998–2003. The difference in the length of reports diminished from six to four times. The relatively large number of stories dealing with Georgia is mostly due to its August 2008 war with Russia. Belarus, Turkmenistan, and Moldova received very little coverage in U.S. television news. (See Table 1.)

The post-Soviet states, excluding Russia, also received less coverage (four-fifths) than their East Central Euro-

pean counterparts, even though the combined population of the post-Soviet countries was about 1.5 times greater. The disparity in the extent of reporting has not changed since 2004, although the disparity in the number of stories declined somewhat (Table 1). A similar pattern characterized most individual post-Soviet and East Central European countries with a similar population size. For example, Ukraine, Uzbekistan, Kazakhstan, and Belarus received much less television coverage in 1998–2009 than their East Central European counterparts with comparable populations. Ukraine lagged significantly behind Poland on both measures of coverage. The number of television reports and the length of the stories concerning Uzbekistan and Kazakhstan were considerably smaller than those of Romania. Similarly, Belarus lagged significantly behind Hungary, Bulgaria, and the Czech Republic. Coverage of Georgia, Armenia, and Kyrgyzstan, however, was more extensive than that of Slovakia. Many post-communist countries, especially Russia, Azerbaijan, Kazakhstan, Moldova, Tajikistan, the Czech Republic, Hungary, and Romania experienced a decline in the number of reports and their length from 2004 to 2009 relative to 1998–2003 (Table 1).

In general, American allies among post-communist states received relatively more favorable coverage compared to adversaries or non-allies (Tables 2 and 3). On average, reporting about countries that had been formal U.S. allies since 1999 was more positive (49 percent) than reporting about countries that allied with the United States in the middle of the last decade (40 percent), and much more positive than the coverage of non-allies and adversaries (12 percent) (Table 2). For instance, when measured by the length of broadcasts on various topics from 1998 to 2009, 66 percent of the coverage on Poland, 48 percent on the Czech Republic, and 32 percent on Hungary was positive. In contrast, 0 percent of the reporting on Belarus, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Uzbekistan, and Turkmenistan; 7 percent on Moldova; 11 percent on Russia; 18 percent on Azerbaijan; 34 percent on Armenia; and 48 percent on Tajikistan was positive. Conversely, negativity characterized 17 percent of television news reports about Poland, 12 percent about the Czech Republic, and 4 percent about Hungary—compared to 93 percent on Moldova, 92 percent on Turkmenistan, 86 percent on Belarus, 76 percent on Kazakhstan, 71 percent on Russia, 66 percent on Armenia, 65 percent on Uzbekistan, 15 percent on Kyrgyzstan, 7 percent on Azerbaijan, and 0 percent on Tajikistan. Other coverage was neutral (Table 1).

There is evidence of selectivity bias in the coverage of allies versus non-allies and East Central European versus

Table 1

Coverage of Post-Communist Countries in 1998–2009

	Population in 2009, million	2004–9		1998–2003		1998–2009 (%)		
		number of stories/ segments	length (thousand words)	number of stories/ segments	length (thousand words)	positive	neutral	negative
Russia	141.9	851	449.3	2018	758.5	11	18	71
Ukraine	45.7	84	36.2	77	54.8	5	44	51
Georgia	4.4	81	28.3	33	7.3	66	19	15
Armenia	3.3	15	15.9	26	14.0	34	0	66
Uzbekistan	27.8	32	13.5	39	12.8	0	34	65
Kyrgyzstan	5.3	10	11.2	9	9.9	0	85	15
Kazakhstan	15.6	12	4.4	13	10.3	0	24	76
Turkmenistan	5.0	4	2.3	3	0.2	0	7	92
Belarus	9.5	5	0.8	3	0.2	0	15	85
Moldova	3.6	1	0.6	5	4.2	7	0	93
Azerbaijan	9.0	2	0.2	15	7.3	18	75	7
Tajikistan	6.8	1	0.1	12	1.2	48	52	0
Post-Soviet	136.0	1,098	562.8	2,253	880.7	16	31	53
Poland	38.1	137	73.3	72	28.1	66	17	17
Romania	21.5	36	33.8	45	39.9	2	70	28
Hungary	10.0	25	19.6	27	27.4	48	40	12
Bulgaria	7.6	17	9.5	27	5.1	73	12	15
Czech Republic	10.5	22	8.4	72	50.0	32	64	4
Slovakia	5.4	5	1.4	10	1.1	52	48	0
East Central European	93.1	242	146.0	253	151.6	46	42	13

Notes: Stories or segments of less than fifty words are excluded. Population figures are from World Bank 2011. The number of stories about Georgia and Poland may be underreported because of search parameters.

post-Soviet countries. For example, the main topic of television reporting on Poland (58 percent of the whole) included overwhelmingly positive reports about Pope John Paul II, whose Polish descent and ties to Poland were emphasized, and about Polish Catholicism. The leading Czech-related topic in terms of length (31 percent) concerned Czech immigrants and their descendants. It received mostly positive coverage. (See Table 4.) Reports about the U.S. missile system in Poland and the Czech Republic focused on the potential benefits of this system to U.S. defense capabilities against Iranian or North Korean missile strikes. While such political stories as U.S.–Czech relations, the U.S. missile defense program, the Czech role in the U.S.-led war in Iraq, and the Czech Republic's accession to NATO and the EU received mostly favorable coverage, they constituted a relatively small fraction of

Table 2

Content of Television Coverage of Allies and Non-Allies in 1998–2009 (% , length)

	Allies	Non-allies/ Allies	Non-allies
Positive	49	40	12
Neutral	40	39	31
Negative	11	22	57
Total	100	100	100

reporting on this country from 1998 to 2009. Similarly, positive reports about Hungarian immigrants or people identified as having Hungarian descent, such as French President Nicolas Sarkozy, constituted the most prominent

Table 3

Content of Television Coverage of Post-Communist Countries Before and After They Turned into U.S. Allies in 1998–2009 (% , length)

	Non-Allies			Allies		
	positive	neutral	negative	positive	neutral	negative
<i>Post-Soviet</i>						
Ukraine	5	42	53	12	48	40
Georgia	22	45	33	78	12	10
Mean	14	44	43	45	30	25
<i>East Central European</i>						
Romania	1	51	47	4	84	12
Bulgaria	45	12	43	93	6	1
Slovakia	7	93	0	96	0	4
Mean	18	52	30	64	30	6

topic of reporting about Hungary since 1998 (21 percent of all stories and 14 percent of their overall length). The overall coverage of Hungary, however, was neutral.

In contrast, reports about some non-allies and the post-Soviet states focused on negative issues. For example, discussions about WMD and their potential proliferation dominated the negative coverage of Kazakhstan, constituting 35 percent of the reports. ABC, CBS, and NBC news broadcasts concerning Armenia and Armenians also focused on the negative: reporting on Armenian criminals and terrorists, primarily in the United States. Positive portrayals of Armenian immigrants and their descendants and the issue of the U.S. government's recognition of the genocide of Armenians in Ottoman Turkey received less coverage. Reportage on spies, spying, and the secret services came close to tying first place in terms of the length of broadcasts concerning Russia. (See Tables 5 and 6.)

Romania and Azerbaijan, among others, were exceptions. Discussions of Romania were dominated by negative stories dealing with abandoned children and orphans (27 percent of the whole) (Table 4). In contrast, Azerbaijan received neutral coverage, dominated by its potential as a major oil producer and exporter.

The television coverage of Bulgaria and Slovakia became overwhelmingly positive after they joined NATO in 2004 (Table 3). Most reports on Bulgaria were positive stories about Bulgarian immigrants in the United States and Bulgarian troops and hostages in Iraq. Positive reporting about the visit of U.S. President George W. Bush characterized broadcasts about Slovakia from May 2004 on. Although television reporting about Romania stayed mostly neutral after the country joined NATO, negative

coverage declined from 47 percent to 12 percent. Coverage of “sex slavery” and “sex slaves” (11 percent), Dracula (11 percent), and immigrants and their descendants (11 percent) in Romania was neutral (Table 4). For example, in contrast to the Borat-related coverage of Kazakhstan, news stories about Dracula were neutral in terms of their content because, together with the negative image of the fictional vampire, they often discussed the invention of this stereotype in the West and its positive impact on the present-day tourism industry in Romania.

Similarly, the coverage of Georgia and Ukraine became relatively more favorable after the “color revolutions” created pro-U.S. governments in these post-Soviet states. For instance, positive reporting about Georgia from 2004 to 2009 made up 78 percent of broadcasts in terms of length, relative to 22 percent in 1998–2003 (Table 3).⁴ The coverage was dominated by the war with Russia in 2008 (Table 5). Georgia was most often presented as a small democratic country that suffered invasion by Russia. The coverage included several interviews with President Mikheil Saakashvili of Georgia, who accused Russia of unprovoked aggression against his country, and with other Georgians. In contrast, hardly any interviews represented the Russian and South Ossetian sides of the conflict. Television news programs on the three leading U.S. networks either failed to mention or minimized the large-scale Georgian attack that started the war on August 7, 2008.⁵ News reports either ignored the Georgian army's indiscriminate use of force during its attack on the South Ossetian capital, which resulted in a significant number of civilian deaths, or conflated it with the Russian counterattack and Georgian civilian casualties. For example, *ABC World News Saturday* reported

Table 4

Content of Coverage of Poland, the Czech Republic, and Romania in 1998–2009 (%)

Subject	Stories/Segments	Words	Content
<i>Poland</i>			
Pope/Polish Catholicism	49.8	57.5	Positive
Crime/criminals	1.9	15.6	Negative
Holocaust/World War II	11.0	12.2	Neutral
U.S.–Polish relations	6.2	2.3	Positive
U.S. missile defense	5.3	2.1	Positive
Immigrants/their descendants	2.9	1.7	Neutral
Iraq War	5.7	1.6	Positive
CIA secret prisons	3.3	1.4	Neutral
Elections/politics/politicians	4.8	1.4	Positive
Jewish immigrants/their descendants/anti-Semitism	1.0	1.4	Neutral
Accidents/disasters	2.9	1.2	Negative
EU and NATO accession	2.4	0.6	Positive
Other	1.9	0.7	Neutral
Total	100	100	Positive
<i>N</i>	209	101.4	
<i>Czech Republic</i>			
Immigrants/their descendants	8.5	31.0	Positive
Crime/criminals	10.6	22.6	Neutral
Sex slaves/sex slavery	2.1	8.9	Negative
U.S.–Czech relations	12.8	6.0	Positive
Accidents/disasters	13.8	5.8	Neutral
Holocaust/World War II	5.3	5.3	Neutral
Jewish immigrants/their descendants/anti-Semitism	3.2	4.3	Positive
U.S. missile defense	6.4	3.3	Positive
Gypsies	1.1	3.3	Negative
Economy/business	4.3	2.7	Neutral
Terrorism	10.6	1.9	Neutral
Velvet Revolution/protests/politicians	6.4	1.5	Neutral
NATO and EU accession	2.1	1.0	Positive
Czech weapons	2.1	0.3	Positive
Nuclear/radioactive materials	1.1	0.3	Neutral
Iraq War	2.1	0.3	Positive
Sports/athletes	2.1	0.3	Positive
Other	5.3	1.4	Positive
Total	100	100	Neutral
<i>N</i>	94	58.3	
<i>Romania</i>			
Abandoned children/orphans	17.3	26.5	Negative
Adopted children	4.9	22.9	Neutral
Sex slaves/sex slavery	7.4	11.4	Neutral

(continues)

Table 4 (continued)

Subject	Stories/Segments	Words	Content
<i>Poland</i>			
Dracula	4.9	11.1	Neutral
Immigrants/their descendants	12.3	10.7	Neutral
CIA secret prisons	7.4	4.2	Neutral
Jewish immigrants/their descendants/anti-Semitism	3.2	3.1	Neutral
Health care/medicine	6.2	2.6	Neutral
Arts/artists/entertainment	6.2	1.8	Neutral
Sports/athletes	6.2	1.2	Positive
U.S.-Romanian relations	6.2	1.2	Positive
Holocaust/World War II	3.7	0.9	Neutral
Accidents/disasters	6.2	0.5	Neutral
Other	8.6	1.9	Negative
Total	100	100	Neutral
<i>N</i>	81	73.7	

on August 9, 2008, that “hundreds, possibly thousands, of civilians [have been] killed, apartment buildings and military bases destroyed, as Russian bombers and missiles pound Georgia, a U.S. ally.”

Positive coverage of Ukraine increased slightly (from 5 to 12 percent) after the Orange Revolution in 2004, when this post-Soviet state started to pursue a pro-Western, pro-American foreign policy that included the intent to join NATO with U.S. backing. Negative reporting on Ukraine declined more noticeably (from 53 to 40 percent) (Table 3). The leading news topic concerning Ukraine focused on the 2004 presidential elections and mass demonstrations against election fraud (23 percent of stories and 11 percent of total length from 1998 to 2009). The coverage included positive representations of Viktor Yushchenko, his pro-Western orientation, and the Orange forces that supported him. Many reports also discussed the government’s falsification of the 2004 presidential election results and the potential for conflict to escalate in Ukraine because of support of Viktor Yanukovich by pro-Russian forces in Ukraine and by the Russian government. The poisoning of Viktor Yushchenko during the 2004 presidential campaign received significant and similarly mixed coverage in U.S. television programming (Table 5).

American news reports on Central Asian countries, which allowed the United States to use their air bases in support of its military operations in Afghanistan, were relatively more favorable, with the exception of Uzbekistan (Table 1). For example, Tajikistan received some of the most positive coverage among the post-Soviet

states. The overall coverage of Kyrgyzstan was mostly neutral despite being dominated by terrorism-related stories. Although television reports about Uzbekistan were mostly negative and focused on Islamist terrorism, this post-Soviet country’s supportive role in the U.S.-led war in Afghanistan received neutral coverage.

Stories about the role of Poland, the Czech Republic, Hungary, and Bulgaria in the Iraq War were positive (Table 4). These countries joined the U.S.-led coalition in Iraq. In contrast, Iraq War–related coverage of Russia, which opposed the American invasion, was negative. Similarly, reports on the Kosovo war involving Russia, which opposed the NATO military campaign, were negative. Televised coverage of the role of Russia, which generally backed the U.S.-led war in Afghanistan, was mixed and relatively marginal compared to the other two conflicts (Table 6). American news programs did not devote much attention to the role of other post-communist countries in the wars in Kosovo, Iraq, and Afghanistan.

Post-Soviet countries generally received more negative coverage than did post-communist countries in East Central Europe. On average, 16 percent of reporting on post-Soviet nations was positive and 53 percent negative, while East Central European countries received 46 percent positive and only 13 percent negative coverage. For instance, reporting on Ukraine in 1998–2009 was, on the whole, negative. U.S. television programs devoted a significant portion of their Ukraine-related coverage to criminals, anti-Semitism, and negative effects of the Chernobyl (Chornobyl) nuclear disaster. The second leading topic of news reports dealing with Ukraine from

Table 5

Content of Coverage of Ukraine, Georgia, and Kazakhstan in 1998-2009 (%)

Subject	Stories/Segments	Words	Content
<i>Ukraine</i>			
Orange Revolution	23.0	14.9	Neutral
Crime/criminals	13.0	12.4	Negative
Jewish immigrants/their descendants/anti-Semitism	1.9	11.1	Negative
Chernobyl (Chornobyl) disaster and its effects	11.2	9.9	Negative
Immigrants/their descendants	5.0	9.7	Neutral
Sex slaves/sex slavery	0.6	6.5	Negative
Pope visit	4.3	5.9	Neutral
Yushchenko's poisoning	6.2	5.8	Neutral
Sports/athletes	1.9	3.7	Positive
Mail-order brides	3.1	3.4	Neutral
Other accidents/disasters	11.2	3.2	Negative
Holocaust/World War II	2.5	2.9	Negative
Leonid Kuchma	1.2	2.8	Negative
Weapons trade	2.5	2.4	Negative
Adopted children	2.5	1.0	Positive
Gas conflict with Russia	1.2	0.4	Positive
Yushchenko's visits	1.2	0.1	Positive
Other	7.5	3.9	Neutral
Total	100	100	Negative
<i>N</i>	161	90.9	
<i>Georgia</i>			
Georgian-Russian war	53.5	61.5	Positive
U.S.-Georgian relations	20.2	13.8	Neutral
Nuclear/radioactive materials	10.5	13.8	Negative
Health care/medicine	0.9	4.5	Positive
Rose Revolution	5.3	3.9	Neutral
Pope visit	1.8	1.1	Neutral
Economy	1.8	0.8	Negative
Terrorism	1.8	0.6	Negative
Other	1.8	0.3	Positive
Total	100	100	Positive

(continues)

Table 5 (continued)

Subject	Stories/Segments	Words	Content
<i>Kazakhstan</i>			
Nuclear/radioactive materials/WMD	24	34.7	Negative
Borat	20	19.7	Negative
Crime/criminals	16	18.4	Negative
Economy	8	16.3	Mixed
Space flights	16	6.8	Mixed
Politicians	4	3.4	Negative
Other	12	1.4	Mixed
Total	100	100	Negative
<i>N</i>	25	14.7	

Table 6

Content of Coverage of Russia in 1998–2009 (%)

Subject	Stories/Segments	Words	Content
U.S.–Russian relations	15.1	9.5	Negative
Spies/spying/secret services	6.3	9.2	Negative
Crime/criminals	3.9	8.7	Negative
Soviet Union as Russia	5.2	6.4	Negative
Terrorism/terrorists	6.0	5.6	Neutral
Immigrants/their descendants	2.1	4.5	Positive
Adopted children	1.0	4.1	Negative
Jewish immigrants/their descendants/anti-Semitism	0.8	3.9	Positive
Accidents/disasters	6.4	3.7	Negative
Chechen wars	5.7	3.7	Negative
Space exploration/cosmonauts	6.9	3.6	Neutral
Economy/business/New Russians	4.5	3.3	Negative
Kosovo war	5.1	3.3	Negative
Nuclear/radioactive materials/WMD	2.1	3.2	Negative
Mail-order brides	0.6	2.8	Neutral
Sport/sportsmen	2.3	2.2	Negative
Boris Yeltsin	3.5	2.2	Negative
Arts/artists/entertainment	1.3	2.1	Positive
Vladimir Putin	2.1	2.0	Neutral
Georgian–Russian war	2.3	2.0	Negative
Elections/protests/media freedom/democracy	2.5	1.9	Negative
Iraq War	4.6	1.8	Negative
Medicine/health care	1.0	1.3	Negative
Military/weapons	1.7	1.3	Negative
Other politicians	1.3	1.3	Neutral

Technology/science	0.4	0.8	Neutral
Relations with Ukraine/Ukraine	0.8	0.7	Negative
Sex slaves/sex slavery	0.3	0.7	Neutral
Religion/priests	0.3	0.6	Neutral
Oligarchs	0.3	0.5	Negative
Abandoned children/orphans	0.4	0.5	Negative
Vodka/alcoholism	0.2	0.4	Positive
Holocaust/World War II	0.1	0.3	Positive
Russian roulette	0.4	0.3	Negative
Sex/prostitution	0.1	0.3	Negative
Climate/Siberia	0.3	0.2	Neutral
Tsar	0.2	0.2	Neutral
Bears	0.1	0.1	Neutral
Afghan War	0.4	0.1	Neutral
Other	1.3	0.7	Negative
Total	100	100	Negative
N	2,869	1,208	

1998 to 2009 was crime and criminals. It was the most prominent topic from 1998 to 2003, when 27 percent of all stories and segments and 21 percent of the total length of the coverage dealing with Ukraine was devoted to this issue. Positive coverage of Ukraine was mostly confined to news reports about sports and athletes (Table 5).

Similarly, U.S. television coverage of Kazakhstan was largely negative. Three leading topics concerning this Central Asian state presented Kazakhstan in negative ways. Reporters paid much attention to security issues with nuclear and radioactive materials and biological WMD left from the Soviet period. Additionally, one-fifth of the coverage was devoted to Borat, a fictional Kazakh television journalist played by a British comedian. The news programs broadcast stories involving this fictional Kazakh reporter and clips from a Hollywood movie called *Borat: Cultural Learnings of America for Make Benefit Glorious Nation of Kazakhstan* (Table 5).

Belarus, which had adversarial relations with the United States, received overwhelmingly negative coverage from the major news programs of ABC, CBS, and NBC. In addition to reports about criminals and negative effects of the Chernobyl (Chornobyl) accident, ABC's *Nightline* produced a long broadcast on May 18, 2005, that presented as a real possibility a Hollywood movie plot in which al Qaeda terrorists obtained highly enriched uranium from a reactor in Belarus and built a nuclear bomb (Table 1).⁶

Reports on Russia, which was neither an ally nor an adversary of the United States, were mostly negative from 1998 to 2009. The main topics included relations between the United States and Russia (about 15 percent of

all stories and almost 10 percent of broadcast length), as well as spying and the poisoning of Alexander Litvinenko in the United Kingdom (6 percent of the stories and 9 percent of the word count) (Table 6). Most stories about U.S.–Russian relations focused on tensions between the countries over the U.S. missile system that the Bush administration proposed to install in Poland and the Czech Republic, the Iran nuclear program, and sanctions against North Korea. Russian foreign policy was frequently presented as aimed at starting a new cold war with the United States, allying itself with Iran, invading Georgia, and restoring the Soviet Union with the use of military force. Coverage of Russia became mixed, however, after relations between the countries improved during the first year of Barack Obama's presidency in 2009.

Terrorism in Russia was another leading political news topic. The television coverage focused on the takeover of a Beslan school by Islamist terrorists in 2004. Many terrorist-related reports included largely positive representations of Russia. For example, they focused on children who were taken hostage during the Beslan attack but survived. The coverage also featured negative aspects, however, such as discussion of Russian government failures to prevent terrorist attacks and avoid the deaths of several hundred hostages in the Beslan school during the rescue operation.

The third most popular topic in terms of length (9 percent) dealt with criminals and crime in Russia. News reports focused on immigrants from Russia or their descendants who were involved or suspected of being involved in various crimes. In contrast to the framing of Hungarian and Czech criminals and crime as neutral cases

with both negative and positive aspects—for example, by focusing on both perpetrators and victims—Russian crime was framed negatively. Russian criminals were often depicted as members of organized crime groups or as threatening to Americans, as in the case of computer hackers.

In contrast to the coverage of Georgian actions during its attack on South Ossetia, news reports about the second war in Chechnya were overwhelmingly negative toward Russia. These broadcasts were mostly framed in terms of human rights violations and war crimes by Russian military forces attacking Chechnya and violently suppressing the pro-independence movement, destroying the capital city of Chechnya, and killing Chechen civilians. Reporters minimized or ignored the role of radical Islamists in Chechnya in attacking the Dagestan region and most likely masterminding terrorist apartment bombings in Moscow as reasons for the start of the war in 1999.

The absolute majority of other major political and nonpolitical news topics concerning Russia received either mostly negative or mostly neutral coverage (Table 6).⁷ Reportage emphasized Putin's reelection as president of Russia, the election of Dmitry Medvedev as his hand-picked successor, the dispersal of demonstrations held by the opposition, the detention of opposition leaders, government control of the mass media, and killings of journalists. Positive stories related to Russia were much less prevalent than negative and neutral reports. Positive coverage was mostly confined to nonpolitical topics—immigrants from Russia and their descendants, arts and entertainment, and so on (Table 6).

More than 5 percent of stories that constituted more than 6 percent of the overall length of television reports by the major news programs of ABC, CBS, and NBC in 1998–2009 explicitly identified the Soviet Union as Russia or incorrectly associated Russia or Russians with the Soviet Union. This happened primarily with references to the cold war, World War II, the Cuban Missile Crisis, and the Soviet war in Afghanistan. For example, a CBS broadcast incorrectly stated that Russia lost 27 million people during World War II, although this number included casualties in the entire Soviet Union. Joseph Stalin was identified with Russia even though he was Georgian. Similarly, many reports incorrectly referred to the Soviet troops in Afghanistan as Russian troops. In addition, in a number of television broadcasts, other post-Soviet states, such as Ukraine and Kazakhstan, were confused with Russia. For example, Mike Wallace, a co-host of *60 Minutes*, referred to Chernobyl (Chornobyl)

as “a Russian town” in the *CBS Evening News* broadcast on March 3, 1999.

The misidentification of Russia with the Soviet Union is much more extensive than this category suggests. For example, many people who were specifically identified in television reports as Russian criminals were not Russian citizens or ethnically Russian. For instance, televised reports concerning the figure-skating scandal during the 2002 Winter Olympics named Alimzhan Tokhtakhunov as a “Russian mobster” even though he was born in Uzbekistan. Similarly, many television reports referred to Americans who were recruited by the Soviet security services but continued to work for Russia after the collapse of the Soviet Union only as Russian agents. The length of broadcasts that directly or indirectly misidentified Russia with the Soviet Union and post-Soviet countries from 1998 to 2009 was comparable to the quantity of reporting about Ukraine, Georgia, Uzbekistan, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Turkmenistan, Tajikistan, Armenia, Azerbaijan, Moldova, and Belarus combined.

Conclusion

Our analysis of major ABC, CBS, and NBC news programs in 1998–2009 shows significant differences in the quantity and content of U.S. television coverage of post-communist countries. Post-Soviet states such as Ukraine, Kazakhstan, Azerbaijan, and Belarus, which became independent only in 1991, received disproportionately low coverage on U.S. television compared to Russia and countries in East Central Europe relative to their population size. This study indicates that one of the main factors that accounts for such disparity is the continuing association of the former Soviet republics with Russia in many reports. The length of broadcasts that directly or indirectly misidentified Russia with the Soviet Union and post-Soviet countries was comparable to all reportage on the other post-Soviet states.

The television coverage of U.S. allies among post-communist countries—Poland, Hungary, and the Czech Republic—was much more favorable than that on U.S. adversaries and non-allies (Belarus, Russia, Uzbekistan, and Kazakhstan). American television broadcasts concerning Bulgaria, Slovakia, Ukraine, and Georgia became significantly more favorable after these countries joined NATO or adopted pro-U.S. foreign policies. The effect of tactical alliances during the wars in Kosovo, Iraq, and Afghanistan on the coverage of post-communist nations was less pronounced but still significant in a number of cases.

Appendix: Coding Scheme for Selected Issues

Subject	Positive	Negative	Neutral
Relations of a country with the United States	U.S. ally, pro-U.S. policies, visits, summits, meetings, agreements, etc., without tensions/disagreements between United States/its leaders with a country/its leaders	Opposition to the United States, anti-U.S. policies, tensions, disagreements, conflicts, problems, illegal activity, etc., between the United States/its leaders and a country/its leaders	Neutral or includes both positive and negative content to a similar extent
Wars in Iraq, Afghanistan, Kosovo	Country/its leader was allied with the United States in U.S.-led wars; supported U.S. government position; opposed anti-American governments in Iraq, Afghanistan, Serbia	Country/its leader did not ally with the United States in U.S.-led wars; opposed U.S. government position; supported anti-U.S. governments in Iraq, Afghanistan, Serbia	Neutral or includes both positive and negative content to a similar extent
Spies, spying, security services	Cooperation with United States in intelligence, etc.	Spying against United States/West; assassinations by security services	Neutral or includes both positive and negative content to a similar extent
Terrorism, terrorists	Focus on victims, while terrorists are identified as foreigners/minorities	Focus on terrorist attacks/terrorists from a country or on failures to prevent terrorism/save hostages; terrorists are identified as representative of a country	Neutral or includes both positive and negative content to a similar extent
Accidents, disasters	Focus on heroes/rescuers or victims of natural disasters from a country	Human made/technological disasters involving a particular country	Neutral or includes both positive and negative content to a similar extent; natural disasters in a particular country without focus on victims
Immigrants, descendants	Renowned/accomplished people; generally positive deeds, victims, etc.	Negative deeds; illegal immigrants, etc.	Neutral or includes both positive and negative content to a similar extent
Sports, athletes	Champions/winners but not against United States	Losers/cheaters/U.S. competitors	Neutral or includes both positive and negative content to a similar extent
Technology, space	Cooperation with United States, accomplishments, etc.	Problems in cooperation with United States; accidents; backward technology, etc.	Neutral or includes both positive and negative content to a similar extent
Weapons, WMD	Disarmament; cooperation with United States; superior weapons	Use/possibility of use by terrorists, U.S. enemies, criminals; inferior weapons	Neutral or includes both positive and negative content to a similar extent

The study also indicates a certain selectivity bias in the coverage of both allies versus non-allies and East Central European versus post-Soviet countries. With some exceptions, such as Georgia and Tajikistan, the post-Soviet states received significantly more negative coverage than post-communist countries in East Central Europe. Such preconceptions against the post-Soviet countries can be attributed to the effects of the anti-Russian bias. This study confirmed findings of several previous studies that reported a prevalence of negative coverage of Russia. Broadcasts on ABC, CBS, and NBC about Russia from 1998 to 2009 were dominated by negative stories, such as tense relations with the United States, crime and criminals, spying and secret services, and undemocratic developments in Russia.

This article, in contrast to most previous studies that focus on the coverage of a single post-communist country, primarily Russia, provides a comparative analysis of eighteen post-communist states. It shows the significance of political factors in the representation of post-communist countries by American television. U.S. television images of post-communist countries are often shaped by such political factors as these countries' relations with the United States. The study demonstrates biases in the coverage of many post-Soviet countries by television news programs of major American networks. Such coverage is likely to have real repercussions; for example, in the area of public attitudes toward post-communist nations and U.S. foreign policy toward post-communist states.

Notes

1. "Nation Brand Perception Indexes," East West Communications (www.eastwestcoms.com).
2. Because significant proportions of U.S. television news stories concerning Tajikistan and Uzbekistan refer to the Uzbek and Tajik minorities in Afghanistan, these news reports are excluded from the analysis.
3. Because Georgia has the same name as the U.S. state of Georgia, the search was limited to stories classified in the Lexis-Nexis database as pertaining to the republic of Georgia. A similar search procedure was used to deal with coincidences of the names "Poles" and "Polish" with other terms that are not related to Poland.
4. An analysis by the number of reports produces similar results.
5. See, for example, reports by monitors from the Organization for Security and Cooperation in Europe and by the European Union special commission, which produced a comprehensive analysis of the war (Independent International Fact-Finding Mission 2009).
6. We used different versions of "Belarus" and "Belarusians" in searching television transcripts.
7. It is noteworthy that traditional stereotypes concerning Russia and Russians—vodka and alcoholism, cold climate and Siberia, bears, and Russian roulette—attracted less television coverage than newly invented stereotypes that associate Russia with children adopted in the United States, mail-order brides, sex slaves, and oligarchs. With the exception of Russian roulette, a fictional game invented by an American writer, the coverage of the traditional stereotypes was not negative. For example, vodka, which was presented as a Russian invention, received mostly favorable coverage because of its growing popularity in the United States (Table 6).

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